CAMBRIDGE
International Education

Cambridge O Level

ENGLISH LANGUAGE **1123/12**

Paper 1 Reading **May/June 2025**

MARK SCHEME

Maximum Mark: 50

Published

This mark scheme is published as an aid to teachers and candidates, to indicate the requirements of the examination. It shows the basis on which Examiners were instructed to award marks. It does not indicate the details of the discussions that took place at an Examiners' meeting before marking began, which would have considered the acceptability of alternative answers.

Mark schemes should be read in conjunction with the question paper and the Principal Examiner Report for Teachers.

Cambridge International will not enter into discussions about these mark schemes.

Cambridge International is publishing the mark schemes for the May/June 2025 series for most Cambridge IGCSE, Cambridge International A and AS Level components, and some Cambridge O Level components.

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Generic Marking Principles

These general marking principles must be applied by all examiners when marking candidate answers. They should be applied alongside the specific content of the mark scheme or generic level descriptions for a question. Each question paper and mark scheme will also comply with these marking principles.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 1:

Marks must be awarded in line with:

- the specific content of the mark scheme or the generic level descriptors for the question
- the specific skills defined in the mark scheme or in the generic level descriptors for the question
- the standard of response required by a candidate as exemplified by the standardisation scripts.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 2:

Marks awarded are always **whole marks** (not half marks, or other fractions).

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 3:

Marks must be awarded **positively**:

- marks are awarded for correct/valid answers, as defined in the mark scheme. However, credit is given for valid answers which go beyond the scope of the syllabus and mark scheme, referring to your Team Leader as appropriate
- marks are awarded when candidates clearly demonstrate what they know and can do
- marks are not deducted for errors
- marks are not deducted for omissions
- answers should only be judged on the quality of spelling, punctuation and grammar when these features are specifically assessed by the question as indicated by the mark scheme. The meaning, however, should be unambiguous.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 4:

Rules must be applied consistently, e.g. in situations where candidates have not followed instructions or in the application of generic level descriptors.

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GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 5: Marks should be awarded using the full range of marks defined in the mark scheme for the question (however; the use of the full mark range may be limited according to the quality of the candidate responses seen).
GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 6: Marks awarded are based solely on the requirements as defined in the mark scheme. Marks should not be awarded with grade thresholds or grade descriptors in mind.

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English & Media subject specific general marking principles

(To be read in conjunction with the Generic Marking Principles (and requiring further guidance on how to place marks within levels))

Components using level descriptors:

- We use level descriptors as a guide to broad understanding of the qualities normally expected of, or typical of, work in a level.
- Level descriptors are a means of general guidance and should not be interpreted as hurdle statements.
- Where indicative content notes are supplied for a question, these are *not* a prescription of required content, and must not be treated as such. Alternative correct points and unexpected answers in candidates' scripts must be given marks that fairly reflect the knowledge and skills demonstrated.
- While we may have legitimate expectations as to the ground most answers may occupy, we must at all times be prepared to meet candidates on their chosen ground, provided it is relevant ground (e.g. clearly related to and derived from a relevant passage/text and meeting the mark scheme requirements for the question).

Components using point-based marking:

Point marking is often used to reward knowledge, understanding and application of skills. We give credit where the candidate's answer shows relevant knowledge, understanding and application of skills in answering the question. We do not give credit where the answer shows confusion.

From this it follows that we:

a DO credit answers which are worded differently from the mark scheme if they clearly convey the same meaning (unless the mark scheme requires a specific term).

b DO credit alternative answers/examples which are not written in the mark scheme if they are correct.

c DO credit answers where candidates give more than one correct answer in one prompt/numbered/scaffolded space where extended writing is required rather than list-type answers. For example, questions that require *n* reasons (e.g. State two reasons).

d DO NOT credit answers simply for using a 'key term' unless that is all that is required. (Check for evidence it is understood and not used incorrectly.)

e DO NOT credit answers which are obviously self-contradicting or trying to cover all possibilities.

f DO NOT give further credit for what is effectively repetition of a correct point already credited unless the language itself is being tested. This applies equally to 'mirror statements' (i.e. polluted/not polluted).

g DO NOT require spellings to be correct, unless this is part of the test. However, spellings of syllabus terms must allow for clear and unambiguous separation from other syllabus terms with which they may be confused (e.g. Corrasion/Corrosion).

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Annotations guidance for centres

Examiners use a system of annotations as a shorthand for communicating their marking decisions to one another. Examiners are trained during the standardisation process on how and when to use annotations. The purpose of annotations is to inform the standard isation and monitoring processes and guide the supervising examiners when they are checking the work of examiners within their team. The meaning of annotations and how they are used is specific to each component and is understood by all examiners who mark the component.

We publish annotations in our mark schemes to help centres understand the annotations they may see on copies of scripts. Note that there may not be a direct correlation between the number of annotations on a script and the mark awarded. Similarly, the use of an annotation may not be an indication of the quality of the response.

The annotations listed below were available to examiners marking this component in this series.

Annotations

Annotation	Meaning
✓	Correct answer
DET	Relevant supporting detail
DEV	Relevant Development of an idea or detail
●	Relevant content point made (Q3a Summary)
✚	Candidate's own vocabulary and structures appropriately used (Q3a Summary)

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Question 1

This question tests the following reading assessment objectives (16 marks)

R1 demonstrate understanding of explicit meanings
R2 demonstrate understanding of implicit meanings and attitudes

Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
1(a)	**In paragraph 1, what was the first physical feature people noticed when they met Jahan?** • (his) hair	1	
1(b)	**In paragraph 2, how did Jahan feel about Istanbul when he first saw it?** **Give <u>two</u> details from the text to support your answer.** **Feeling** Reward any sense of being **fascinated** or feeling of **intrigue** or **uncertainty** however expressed, such as • entranced / mesmerised / spellbound / bewitched / overwhelmed / absorbed / attracted / awe / hypnotised / curious / interested / confused / unsure // amazed / astonished / stunned (suggest sense of wonder) (1) **Details** Details must come from separate bullets. Award 1 mark for each detail up to a maximum of 2 marks: • 'had a strange effect on his imagination' • 'peered (intently)' / 'stared' // looked closely • 'hazy' (strip of grey)' // unclear • (Istanbul / it / 'the land seemed) an extension of the sea' / • 'a molten city' / 'swaying' / 'dizzying' / 'ever-changing' • 'could fall under its spell' // become spellbound (2)	3	✓ Correct feeling DET Supporting detail *The supporting details can be quoted or paraphrased. A paraphrase must clearly convey the original meaning.* *Do NOT accept line references (only) or ellipses for textual details.* *ACCEPT 'spellbound' as a feeling or detail but <u>not</u> both.*

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
1(c)	**Explain why Jahan 'hurried back below deck.' (line 15)** Award 1 mark for any of the following: • to tell the elephant they had made it to Istanbul / had reached the destination / had arrived • to check on the elephant // he was worried about the elephant // to see if the elephant was OK	**1**	*Bullet 1 ACCEPT any suggestion of him sharing the news of arrival with the elephant* *Bullet 2 ACCEPT any suggestion of his concern for the elephant* *ACCEPT Chota / friend for the elephant*
1(d)	**From paragraph 5, identify two details about the elephant's physical health that showed that he was unwell.** Award 1 mark for each bullet up to a maximum of 2 marks: • sitting (so) still // did not move • (soft,) ragged / difficulty breathing • brightness had gone from his eyes // his eyes were dull • swollen trunk	**2**	*ACCEPT in either order or if both responses are in one limb or if a correct answer straddles both limbs*
1(e)	**From paragraph 5, give two reasons why Jahan thought the elephant's life would be better at the palace.** Award 1 mark for each bullet up to a maximum of 2 marks: • (he will be washed with) fresh water • the royals / the palace / they will adore him / love him / be kind / be caring	**2**	*ACCEPT in either order or if both responses are in one limb or if a correct answer straddles both limbs*

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
1(f)(i)	**In paragraph 6, the sailors found it difficult to get the elephant out of the ship. What was the first problem the sailors had?** Award 1 mark for any of the following bullets: • he refused to move / did not move / would not be moved / was not ready to move // he would not get out (of his crate) • they could not get him to move	**1**	*LOOK FOR any suggestion of the elephant's unwillingness to move* *he refused (alone) = 0*
1(f)(ii)	**How did the sailors solve this problem?** • winched / pulled up / lifted / hoisted the crate (with him inside)	**1**	*LOOK FOR suggestion of crate rising (e.g. pulled **up**)*
1(g)	**Using your own words, explain what the text means by 'ultimately managing'. (line 34)** Award 1 mark for each bullet up to a maximum of 2 marks • **('ultimately')** in the end / eventually / at last / finally / after many tries / gradually • **('managing')** they were able (to) / they did it / they succeeded / they could / they made it happen	**2**	*Bullet 1 'ultimately': LOOK FOR a suggestion of it taking time / a long process* *Bullet 2 'managing' e.g. they were able to thrust the crate on to a cart = 1 mark for 'able'*

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<table>
<tr><th>Question</th><th>Answer</th><th>Marks</th><th>Guidance</th></tr>
<tr><td>1(h)</td><td>
Explain <u>using your own words</u> Jahan's different feelings about the elephant.

Give three details from anywhere in the text to support your answer.
<table>
<tr><th>Jahan feels ✓</th><th>Supporting textual detail DET</th></tr>
<tr><td>1 love / loyalty / a bond / friendship / protective / caring</td><td>'hurried back below deck' / 'my friend!' / 'I'll come with you' / 'wishing, with all his being, for this man to make the elephant better' / 'always carried' sweet almonds / 'smiling' as he gives him 'sweet almonds'</td></tr>
<tr><td>2 concern / worried / scared / uneasy / fear / anxious / dread</td><td>'uttered with a slight quaver' / 'he didn't know what kind of a place here was' / '(feared) the elephant's heart had stopped beating' / '(uneasy about) yet again using seawater' / 'watched the men toil' / 'his anxiety growing' / 'scampered back and forth' / '(dreading) the animal would love the healer more than he loved him'</td></tr>
<tr><td>3 pity / sympathy / sad empathy / sorry</td><td>'ragged breathing' / 'swollen trunk' / brightness had gone from the eyes' / 'left salty marks all over his skin which must have prickled' / 'dangling in the air' / 'Chota was on the brink of collapse'</td></tr>
<tr><td>4 helpless / useless / frustrated / confused</td><td>'uneasy about yet again using seawater' / 'scampered back and forth' / 'trying to lend a hand but not knowing quite how' / Chota 'dangling in the air'</td></tr>
<tr><td>5 guilty / ashamed / uncomfortable / small</td><td>'uneasy about yet again using seawater' / Taras 'glared at Jahan' / 'clearly blaming him for the elephant's condition' / 'The boy felt small and ashamed' / 'lowered his gaze, (uncomfortably)' / '(uncomfortably) aware that Chota was on the brink of collapse'</td></tr>
</table>
</td><td>3</td><td>
<table>
<tr><td>✓</td><td>Each correct feeling</td></tr>
<tr><td>DET</td><td>Supporting textual detail</td></tr>
</table>

Do <u>NOT</u> accept

line or paragraph references (only)
ellipses to substitute words

</td></tr>
</table>

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<table>
<tr><th>Question</th><th>Answer</th><th>Marks</th><th>Guidance</th></tr>
<tr><td>1(h)</td><td>
<table>
<tr><td>Jahan feels ✓</td><td>Supporting textual detail DET</td></tr>
<tr><td>6 threatened / jealous / envy / insecure / possessive</td><td>‘Jealousy gnawed at the boy’s heart’ / ‘dreading the animal would love the healer more than he loved him’</td></tr>
<tr><td>7 happy / reassured / proud / relief / hopeful / excited</td><td>‘hurried back below deck’ / ‘You’ve made it’ / ’Detecting Chota’s (soft, ragged) breathing’ / ‘Jahan felt a small relief’ / ‘they will adore you’ / ‘look resplendent in his new saddlecloth’ / ‘smiling, as Chota popped the nuts into his mouth’</td></tr>
</table>
The supporting textual detail can be quoted or paraphrased. A paraphrase must clearly convey the original meaning,
– e.g. he felt worried because Chota was unwell = feeling 2 only
(attempt at paraphrase, ‘Chota was unwell’, is too general for a text detail) he felt worried that Chota was not breathing = feeling 2 + DET (‘was not breathing’ = acceptable paraphrase of ‘the elephant’s heart had stopped beating’)
</td><td>3</td><td></td></tr>
</table>

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Question 2

This question tests reading assessment objective (9 marks)

R4 demonstrate understanding of how writers achieve effects and influence readers

Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
2(a)	**Read this sentence from the text:** **'They reached the Palace Gate under the stern gaze of the guards who showed no interest in elephants or boys who would become famous one day.' (lines 37–38)** **What does the writer want to suggest to us about what happens to Jahan later in life?** • he becomes famous / (well)known / popular	1	
2(b)	**Explain why the writer uses the word 'mammoth' rather than 'large' in the phrase 'a mammoth door with iron studs'. (line 39)** • it is huge / very large / really big / unusually big // to emphasise the largeness // (to show) how big/ association with the elephant	1	
2(c)	**Read this sentence from the text:** **'They were taken to a barn with an earthen floor and lofty ceiling – Chota's new airy home.' (line 42)** **What effect does the writer suggest about the barn by using the phrase 'airy home' to describe it?** Award 1 mark for each bullet up to a maximum of 2 marks: • where Chota will live / settle / stay // his house // permanent • safe / secure • spacious / large / ventilated / cool / light // open (place) • pleasant / comfortable / calm / suitable • contrast with / better than / not as bad as the (confined) ship / crate	2	

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance
2(d)	**Read this sentence from the text:** **'Inside was a sullen fellow of an age that was impossible to determine who glared at Jahan, clearly blaming him for the animal's condition.' (lines 43–44)** **What <u>two</u> impressions of Taras does the writer want to convey to the reader in this sentence?** Award 1 mark for each bullet up to a maximum of 2 marks: • bad tempered / glum / unfriendly / unapproachable / cold • difficult to work out his age // (could be) old / young // age is ambiguous • critical / aggressive / judgemental / angry / disappointed / unhappy / intimidating // he thinks Jahan is at fault (for Chota's condition) • caring / protective / concerned (about animals / Chota)	**2**	

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<table>
<tr><th>Question</th><th>Answer</th><th>Marks</th><th>Guidance</th></tr>
<tr><td>2(e)</td><td>
Identify <u>one example</u> from the text below of how the writer uses language effectively to convey how the elephant is healed by Taras: (1)

‘Taras examined Chota’s mouth, eyes and trunk. Jahan lowered his gaze, uncomfortably aware that Chota was on the brink of collapse. Taras had magical fingers that healed animals, though were of no use when it came to human diseases. Deftly, gingerly, he applied a foul-smelling lotion to Chota’s trunk, wrapping it with sacking full of crushed leaves and fragrant oil. Not knowing how else to help, the boy brought the bucket of fresh clear water as instructed, placing it next to piles of apples, cabbages and hay– a banquet.’ (lines 44–50)

Explain the impression the writer creates in the example you have identified. (2)

Candidates must select from the following relevant examples <u>in part</u>, <u>whole</u> or <u>combined</u>:

<table>
<tr><th>Example ✓1 mark</th><th>Explanation ✓up to 2 marks</th></tr>
<tr><td>1 ‘examined Chota’s mouth, eyes and trunk’</td><td>looks very closely, thoroughly, inspects // (like) a doctor, vet // professional, expert, knowledgeable</td></tr>
<tr><td>2 ‘had magical fingers (that healed animals)’</td><td>(like) a wizard, sorcerer // powerful, able, skilful, successful, good, expert // miraculous, gifted blessed, extraordinary, unbelievable, unreal, incredible, a mystery // as if he casts a spell, charm // his touch, hands, fingers is/are special, powerful</td></tr>
<tr><td>3 ‘Deftly, gingerly, he applied a foul-smelling lotion’</td><td>(applies lotion with) expertise, skill, confidence, speed // gentle, delicate, kind, careful, does not want to hurt Chota // strong, horrible smell // smell suggests the power of the lotion // knowledgeable (about treatment)</td></tr>
</table>
</td><td>3</td><td>Example: Do NOT accept line references (only). If ellipses are included, only accept the words which are given. If sense is lost, do not award the mark.

Example: ACCEPT a single word if rich enough to create an effect,
e.g. ‘banquet’, ‘deftly’
but NOT words which only carry literal meaning,
e.g. ‘fingers’, ‘lotion’, ‘applied’</td></tr>
</table>

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<table>
<tr><th>Question</th><th>Answer</th><th>Marks</th><th>Guidance</th></tr>
<tr><td>2(e)</td><td>
<table>
<tr><th>Example ✓</th><th>Explanation ✓</th></tr>
<tr><td>4 ‘wrapping it with sacking full of crushed leaves / fragrant oil’</td><td>covers, protects it, the trunk // confident, expert, knowledgeable // natural ingredients, traditional medicine // a complex, unique, special treatment // uses nice-smelling, perfumed oil</td></tr>
<tr><td>5 ‘bucket of fresh clear water (as instructed)’</td><td>refreshing / pure // a reminder of Jahan’s promise of fresh water</td></tr>
<tr><td>6 ‘piles of apples, cabbages and hay’</td><td>plenty, heaps (of apples etc) // nourishing, wholesome // foods an elephant would enjoy // delicious // (well) looked after</td></tr>
<tr><td>7 ‘a banquet’</td><td>a feast, lots of food, extravagance // tasty, delicious, appealing // provided with the very best // (well) looked after // appropriate for a sultan’s elephant</td></tr>
</table>
</td><td></td><td>Explanation: LOOK FOR understanding of the connotations / impact / effect of particular word(s) / image / technique <u>in the identified example</u>.

Explanation: These ideas are suggestions. Candidates may offer other creditworthy ideas.</td></tr>
</table>

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Question 3(a)

This question tests the following reading assessment objectives (10 marks)

R1 demonstrate understanding of explicit meanings
R5 select and use information for specific purposes

and the following writing assessment objectives (10 marks)

W2 organise and structure ideas and opinions for deliberate effect
W3 use a range of vocabulary and sentence structures appropriate to context

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Question	Answer	Marks	Guidance

3(a)	**Summarise the arguments against the plans for the zoo, according to Text B.**
	
	You must <u>use continuous writing</u> (not note form).
	Use your own words as far as possible.
	Avoid copying long sections of the text.
	Your summary should be no more than 150 words.
	
	<u>Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 10 marks for the quality of your writing.</u>
	
	Use the Marking Criteria for **Question 3** (Table **R**, **Reading** and Table **W**, **Writing**).
	
	INDICATIVE READING CONTENT
	
	Candidates may refer to any of the points below:
	
	1 tourist attraction / famous / beautiful / iconic
	2 has been there 130 years / decades // is historic / old
	3 (new location is over) 40 km / far / further away // takes <u>two</u> bus rides (to get to) // hard to get to
	4 construction / building work will cause disruption / chaos
	5 220 apartments // unnecessary / too many apartments / offices / buildings
	6 generations / families have visited // people love / remember / are attached to it
	7 youngsters will not see rare / endangered / wild animals (up close)
	8 (some popular) animals are being sold (to other zoos) // (popular) animals are moving / sent to other zoos // a small number of / not all animals are moving (to new site)
	9 animals to be transported / moved / sent long distances / many kilometres (to other zoos) // transport / movement of animals is unsafe / can cause stress / anxiety
	10 loss of jobs / unemployment
	11 no (public) consultation / discussion
	12 (new site) has less / little land / is small(er)
	13 parking restricted / not enough parking (at the new site) // no parking
		20	

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Marking criteria for Question 3(a)

Table R, Reading

Use the following table to give a mark out of 10 for reading.

Level	Marks	Description
5	**9–10**	• A wide range of relevant ideas (R1) • Ideas are skilfully selected and used (R5)
4	**7–8**	• A good range of relevant ideas (R1) • Ideas are carefully selected and used (R5)
3	**5–6**	• A range of relevant ideas (R1) • Relevant ideas selected; may include excess material (R5)
2	**3–4**	• Some relevant ideas used; may include indiscriminate selection (R1 and R5)
1	**1–2**	• Some ideas referred to; limited evidence of selection (R1and R5)
0	**0**	No creditable content

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Table W, Writing

Use the following table to give a mark out of 10 for writing.

Level	Marks	Description
5	**9–10**	**A relevant response that is expressed clearly, fluently and mostly with concision** • The response is well organised (W2) • The response is the candidate's own words and / or structures where appropriate with a range of vocabulary which clarifies meaning (W3)
4	**7–8**	**A relevant response that is expressed clearly with some areas of concision** • The response is organised (W2) • The response is the candidate's own words and / or structures where appropriate (W3)
3	**5–6**	**A relevant response that is generally expressed clearly** • There is some evidence of organisation (W2) • The response is mainly the candidate's own words and / or structures where appropriate (W3)
2	**3–4**	**A relevant response that can generally be followed** • There are areas of the response expressed in the candidate's own words and / or structures (W2 and W3)
1	**1–2**	**The response lacks clarity** • There may be long explanations or the response may be brief (W2) • There is occasional use of own words and / or structures (W3)
0	**0**	No creditable content

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Question 3(b)

This question tests the following reading assessment objective (5 marks)

R2 demonstrate understanding of implicit meanings and attitudes

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<table>
<tr><th>Question</th><th>Answer</th><th>Marks</th><th>Guidance</th></tr>
<tr>
<td>3(b)</td>
<td>
<u>Imagine you are animal welfare campaigner, conservationist and documentary maker, Lucy Graves.</u>

You are taking part in a television programme about ‘Project Planet’.

Give your answer to the interviewer’s question, using information from the text.

<u>Interviewer’s question</u>: Our audience may be surprised to hear that you’ve worked closely with the zoo on ‘Project Planet’. Many people are against this project.

What is your opinion and why?

Relevant perspective: Lucy Graves supports ‘Project Planet’

INDICATIVE CONTENT

Responses might use any of the following ideas / details:

<table>
<tr><th>Supporting details from the text ✓</th><th>Developments DEV</th></tr>
<tr><td>1 animal welfare campaigner // conservationists involved</td><td>• taking advice from experts / evidence that project aims to protect, preserve animals, their habitats</td></tr>
<tr><td>2 education, teaching, raising awareness // not just entertainment, fun // virtual reality // interactive displays // 4D documentaries // innovative / innovative</td><td>• visitors get a deeper understanding of animals / look at why animals are at risk, effect of climate change etc. more than a conventional zoo would allow / youngsters will engage with computer technology / creative / exciting</td></tr>
</table>
</td>
<td>5</td>
<td>
<table>
<tr><td>✓</td><td>An idea or a detail from the text supporting a valid perspective</td></tr>
<tr><td>DEV</td><td>Development of a point / an idea</td></tr>
</table>

For DEVELOPMENT, look for expansion of a point or detail, or an idea not explicit in the text but a valid inference

DEVELOPMENTS (right-hand column) are examples; candidates may offer other creditworthy suggestions
</td>
</tr>
</table>

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<table>
<tr><th>Question</th><th>Answer</th><th>Marks</th><th>Guidance</th></tr>
<tr><td>3(b)</td><td>
<table>
<tr><th>Supporting details from the text ✓</th><th>Developments DEV</th></tr>
<tr><td>3 important research // species survival plan // protect at-risk, endangered species, habitats // focus on animals most in need of help</td><td>• zoos have changed / studying threats to animals / more important to prevent animals going extinct, losing habitat than entertainment</td></tr>
<tr><td>4 a bigger world picture // making an impact for the future</td><td>• a crucial role in the global movement to protect animals / without research, there will be consequences - no tigers, lions, lemurs for future generations</td></tr>
<tr><td>5 rural location // new, far larger enclosures</td><td>• improved conditions / city no place for wild animals / closer to natural habitat / nostalgia for old site with smaller enclosures does not help animals</td></tr>
<tr><td>6 older zoo residents, black-eyed lemurs will be there</td><td>• there will still be interesting animals to see</td></tr>
<tr><td>7 free bus service, public transport // restricted parking</td><td>• no need to drive / more environmentally friendly / save money</td></tr>
</table>
</td><td></td><td></td></tr>
</table>

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Table R, Reading

Use the following table to give a mark out of 5 for reading.

Level	Marks	Description
3	**4–5**	• Consistent and relevant perspective offered • Ideas are supported and developed
2	**2–3**	• Generally relevant perspective offered • Some attempt to support or develop
1	**1**	• Some awareness of opinion or attitude
0	**0**	No creditable content

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